



## *The Desktop Metaphor*

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In the early eighties, some software engineers at Xerox's Palo Alto Research Center (PARC) began working on more effective ways to allow people to communicate with computers. Their studies found that most people process pictures faster than words, and that they prefer to manipulate their work as directly as possible. Based on these results, they began designing a brand new user interface that was intuitive, pictorial, and direct. (The user interface is how you, the user, communicate with your computer. Early user interfaces were based on typing commands. Today's Graphic User Interfaces, also called GUIs, owe a lot to Xerox's research.)

Steve Jobs, co-founder of Apple and father of the Macintosh, saw an early version of the Xerox team's user interface on a visit to PARC. He decided that the basic elements of the Xerox user interface (an on-screen pointer linked to a pointing device called a mouse, along with movable windows, small pictures called icons, and a compact pull-down menu system) would be a part of Apple's next computer—the Lisa.

The Lisa, which cost \$10,000, was a less-than-stunning commercial success, so Apple soon dumped it and introduced a similar but less expensive computer—the Macintosh. The rest of *that* story is, of course, history—and the technology also made its way to the Apple II line. The Apple II GS is the first Apple II to feature built-in support for the Apple Desktop user interface.

### *So What's The Metaphor?*

For keeping cows in, of course. But seriously, a metaphor (when you're talking about computers—forget the definition you learned in English class) is simply a computerized model of the real world. Most people work at a desk; the desktop metaphor is a way of allowing you to do work on the computer in a manner as close as possible to the way you work in the real world, using simulations of familiar tools.

Of course, the simulation isn't perfect. No one who works with a computer *really* thinks they're working on a desktop. Most people's desks aren't the bright blue of the IIGS Desktop, for one thing, and when writing notes on a real notepad most people don't reach for the Edit menu to select Cut when they make a mistake. But the Apple Desktop has been tested and refined to such an extent over the years that the IIGS is probably as easy to use as a computer can be—at least until the next user interface breakthrough. The Desktop's goal is to make the computer an extension of your mind, so you can work without thinking about how to use the computer.